

FUTURE SKILLS SERIES

AI Literacy • Lesson 3 of 6

THE FACT DESK LESSON

Hallucination Hunters

Smooth is not the same as **true**.

Grades 6–8

45-min lesson

No prep • No devices needed



STUDENT SESSION • THE COMET

The Fact Desk



Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

A note from Deja, who runs The Comet, the school paper: "You're on the fact team. Three writers used an AI helper. Remember: AI guesses the most likely words — it does not check them — so it can be completely wrong and still sound sure. No story gets printed until you check it."

Desk words: run = it gets printed • clear = it passes the check • log = write it down • second source = a place to check that is NOT where you first saw the claim • "the ending still stands" = it is still true once the facts are fixed

Your method, every draft: 1. **UNDERLINE** every checkable claim (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes). 2. **RANK** — write **C** above claims to CHECK, **S** above SAFE ones. 3. **LATERAL-READ** — leave the draft. Log a second source that could confirm each C. 4. **VERDICT** — tick a stamp, give your evidence and say if the writer's ending still stands.

🔍 DRAFT #1 — PRIYA'S SCIENCE COLUMN, "MOON FACTS"

The Moon is Earth's only natural satellite. Astronauts first landed on the Moon in 1959, and Neil Armstrong was the first person to walk on its surface. By 1972, twelve people had walked on the Moon. On a clear night the Moon seems to shine because it produces its own light — which is why it's the brightest thing in the night sky.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)		SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT	

☐ **RUN** — clean, print it
 ☐ **FIX** — correct it, then print
 ☐ **KILL** — cut the story

Note to Priya — what's wrong, your second source, and does her ending still stand?

FOR THE TEACHER

Teacher Guide & Answer Key



Hallucination Hunters — every planted error with the true fact, second-source key, verdict guidance, exit ticket key, what to do when it goes sideways, standards map.

WHY THIS LESSON

Every AI job runs **human** → **AI** → **human**: a person starts it (the prompt) and a person ends it (the check). This lesson trains the second human job. The core insight students leave with: AI predicts *likely* words, not *verified* words — so smoothness is zero evidence of truth. Lateral reading (leave the answer, confirm against a second, independent source) is the move fact-checkers are taught; it works on AI answers, group-chat rumors, and feeds alike. Stands alone.

ANSWER KEY — WARM-UP PARAGRAPH (READ-ALOUD)

PLANTED ERROR	THE TRUE FACT
"The closest planet to the Sun is Venus, which is also the hottest."	Mercury is closest to the Sun. Venus is the hottest (its thick atmosphere traps heat) — the reason is what makes this one slippery.
"Saturn... is the only planet in our solar system that has [rings]."	Jupiter, Uranus, and Neptune also have rings — faint ones. Saturn's are just the most visible.
True claims a desk should mark SAFE or confirm ; the desk checks: Mars is red from rusty iron dust on its surface; sunlight takes about eight minutes to reach Earth.	

WHEN IT GOES SIDEWAYS

A desk asks "is this one true?" → "That's a checkable claim — where's your second source?" Play the editor, not the answer key; keep deadline energy ("Presses roll in five!").

The trusting desk clears everything ("it sounded right") → send them back to step 1: "Did you underline the dates and names? Start there." Every draft has at least one wrong date or name.

The paranoid desk kills everything ("it's all suspicious") → that's what RANK is for: "Which claim would hurt most if wrong? Check that one first." The goal is calibrated doubt, not panic.

A desk treats the Draft #3 quote as proof ("it's in quotation marks") → the boss level. Desk rule: a quote is a claim — no traceable source, no print. Expect some students to need this said twice.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (DEBRIEF, OR THE NEXT DAY)

- Most of the room voted to print the warm-up paragraph. What made it *feel* true? (Smooth sentences, confident tone, real-sounding details.)
- Why is a fabricated quote more dangerous than a wrong date? (A date is easy to check; a quote borrows a real person's credibility.)
- Marcus's ending was an opinion built on a false fact. Can an opinion be "wrong"? (It can be unsupported — when the evidence under it fails, so does the argument.)

THE FACT DESK LESSON • LESSON 3 OF 6

Hallucination Hunters



A 45-minute AI fact-checking lesson. Students run the fact desk at the school paper — nothing gets printed until they clear it. They learn why AI can be confidently wrong, and the four-step method that catches it. Stands alone.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	The Fact Desk worksheet (3 pages, 1 per student) • Slides (optional) • board or chart paper for the RUN / FIX / KILL tally	None — fully unplugged; devices only add	Print worksheets. That's it.

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN...

- Explain why AI "hallucinates": it predicts likely words, so it can be confidently wrong.
- Identify the checkable claims in a text (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes) and rank them by risk.
- Lateral-read a claim — name a second, independent source that could confirm it — and give an evidence-based verdict: RUN, FIX, or KILL.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

CCSS ELA RI.6.8

ISTE 1.3.b

ISTE 1.3.d

Full text + taught/assessed map for each code in the Teacher Guide.

DIFFERENTIATION

- **Support:** Drafts #1–2 only, with the hint "two facts per draft (plus a shaky ending)."
- **Extension:** Write a smooth four-sentence passage with ONE planted error; trade desks and hunt.
- **ELL:** Label the claim TYPE (name, date, number, place, quote) above each underline; partners read aloud; desk words are glossed on p. 1.
- **No-device classroom:** Built in — students name the source they would check. **With devices:** desks open that source and check their top C claims live.

Q & A SETUP — THE STORY THAT ALMOST RAN (6 MIN)

Read this aloud, smooth and confident, like a news anchor. Then call the vote: "This is going in tomorrow's paper. Print it?"

"Our solar system has eight planets orbiting one star, the Sun. The closest planet to the Sun is Venus, which is also the hottest. Mars is called the Red Planet because rusty iron dust covers its surface. Saturn is famous for its rings — it is the only planet in our solar system that has them. Sunlight takes about eight minutes to reach Earth."

Expect most of the room to vote print. Reveal: **two sentences are false.** Mercury is closest to the Sun (Venus really is the hottest — the half-truth is what makes it slippery), and Saturn isn't alone: Jupiter, Uranus, and Neptune have faint rings too.

If the room votes **HOLD**: ask which sentence they doubt — most name Saturn and miss Venus. "One doubt is a start. The desk finds BOTH." If a kid names Venus instantly: "Write it down. We vote first, then we check." The second error usually slips past anyway.

Bridge (say it): "That sounded right because it was SMOOTH, not because it was TRUE. AI talks like that all the time — it predicts likely words; it doesn't check them. Today you're the fact desk: nothing gets printed until you clear it."